‘Good evening, candidates. You must be tired, but don’t worry. We will finish this test quickly. And remember, only those who qualify in this test will appear for the machine tests. So all the best.’

I listened to him carefully. I knew I had to qualify—I had to fly, that was the aim. ‘The Instruments Battery Test will comprise two parts. It is to check your ability to read and interpret the dials of an instrument panel of an aircraft . . .’ he continued. The officer showed us large dummy meters—a compass meter, a climbing or diving meter, a horizon detector and an altimeter. He briefly explained their utility and functioning. ‘Any questions?’ he asked. No one said a word, so he called a warrant officer and a sergeant, who distributed the answer sheets. And so the test began . . .

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August 1976

Very rarely does one experience joy and pain simultaneously. One must be mature enough to understand such a feeling in the first place. But I was far from mature when I first experienced this. What does a two-year-old know anyway? I only knew that if there was something that drew my attention, I had to get to it. Curiosity ran in my veins. Little did I know that what drew my attention in the backyard of our Jhansi bungalow, one that my father had been allotted when he was posted to the Jhansi military station, would accompany me wherever I went in the future.

Betwa Nursery was in the vicinity, so Papaji and Maa had planned to start sending me there to spend time with the other kids and learn. Dada had already been going to the nursery, so I felt left behind at home. I would cry whenever Dada left for school every day. Some days I just wouldn’t stop. At last, Maa reasoned with the headmistress and received permission for me to sit next to Dada in his class. But the permission was given for only two hours. Still, I was content. It was too early, Papaji’s friends would say. ‘But my Gunju already feels bored at home and it’s hard for us to contain her energy. She needs newer things to learn,’ he would tell them. A playschool